

ENTREPRENEURSHIP EDUCATION PRACTICES IN GEORGIA

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ABSTRACT

Entrepreneurship education (EE) has become a strategic priority for Georgia as it seeks to foster innovation, job creation, and economic diversification. This paper examines entrepreneurship education practices in Georgia, drawing on national policy documents, international assessments, and insights from recent conferences and workshops. The analysis highlights both achievements and persistent challenges in integrating entrepreneurship into the education system. Results indicate that universities play a central role through incubators, startup competitions, and international partnerships, while secondary and vocational education increasingly adopt entrepreneurial competencies within curricula. Experiential learning approaches—such as hackathons, internships, and student-run enterprises—are emphasized as effective practices. However, significant barriers remain, including limited teacher training, insufficient access to finance, and uneven participation across rural and marginalized groups. The discussion situates Georgia's efforts within international literature, underscoring the importance of systemic supports, industry linkages, and policy coherence. The paper concludes that while Georgia has advanced from pilot initiatives toward institutionalized practices, scaling requires sustained reforms in teacher development, inclusive programming, and resource allocation. The findings contribute theoretically to debates on EE in transitional economies and provide practical implications for policymakers, educators, and industry stakeholders seeking to strengthen entrepreneurship education as a driver of sustainable development.

Keywords: Entrepreneurship education, innovation, vocational and higher education, policy reform.

INTRODUCTION

Entrepreneurship education (EE) equips learners with the attitudes, knowledge, and skills required to identify opportunities, create value, and adapt in uncertain labor markets. For Georgia — a small, transitional economy pursuing innovation-led growth — embedding entrepreneurship education across formal and non-formal learning environments is a policy priority to stimulate job creation, diversify the economy, and improve youth employability. This paper analyzes the state of entrepreneurship education in Georgia by synthesizing outcomes and discussions from recent national initiatives and sectoral reports. It examines current practices, identifies gaps, and draws implications for policy and practice.

LITERATURE REVIEW

International scholarship on entrepreneurship education emphasizes two core themes: (1) the importance of experiential, practice-based pedagogy to develop entrepreneurial competencies (Fayolle & Gailly, 2008; Kolb, 1984) and (2) the need for systemic supports — teacher training, institutional incubation, and industry linkages — to translate classroom learning into venture creation and employabil-

ity (Gibb, 2002; European Training Foundation reports). Empirical studies from transitional economies suggest that contextualized EE (locally relevant projects, rural value-chains) increases student engagement and economic impact. Within Georgia, policy and analytical documents document a nascent but growing portfolio of EE activities (curriculum pilots, university incubators, and NGO-led programs), while noting constraints including fragmented initiatives, limited teacher capacity, and funding gaps for student ventures.

METHODS / THEORETICAL BACKGROUND

This paper uses qualitative synthesis of publicly available sources (conference and workshop reports, national strategy documents, institutional program pages, and international assessments) combined with thematic analysis to identify dominant patterns in Georgian EE practice. The theoretical framing draws on constructivist and experiential learning theories (Vygotsky; Kolb), which view entrepreneurship learning as active, social, and context-dependent; and on system-level approaches to education reform that emphasize policy coordination, capacity building, and resource alignment. Primary documents reviewed included the Unified National Strategy of Education and Science (Georgia 2022–2030), European Training Foundation country materials, World Bank reports on entrepreneurship and education reform, UNECE workshop outputs, and university incubator program descriptions. Thematic categories for analysis were: curriculum design, pedagogy (experiential learning), teacher preparation, institutional support (incubators/accelerators), financing and networks, and equity/inclusion.

RESULTS

The analysis of national documents, institutional program pages, and sector reports revealed the following core findings:

1. Curriculum and Program Diversity: Georgian education providers deploy a mix of approaches: standalone entrepreneurship courses (mainly at higher education), cross-curricular integration (in some secondary/vocational settings), and short experiential modules (workshops, bootcamps). The Unified National Strategy (2022–2030) signals intent to strengthen relevance and employability across levels, including competencies related to innovation and entrepreneurship.

2. Growth of University Incubation and Networks: Several Georgian universities have institutionalized incubation or entrepreneurship support — Ilia State University, Georgian Technical University, and others host incubators, startup competitions, and industry engagement platforms. Membership in international innovation networks (e.g., Ilia State University joining EBN) signals increased connectivity for Georgian higher education actors.

3. Emphasis on Experiential Learning: Effective practices highlighted in reports and workshops include student-run enterprises, hackathons, pitch competitions, internships, and long-duration project work that allow students to iterate on ideas and engage with markets. UNECE and ETF initiatives have promoted toolkits and competency frameworks for such 21st-century skills.

4. Teacher and Capacity Gaps: Multiple sources point to a shortage of teachers with practical entrepreneurial experience and limited pre-service and in-service training focused on project-based pedagogy. This teacher capacity gap constrains quality and scale.

5. Access to Finance and Networks Insufficient: While accelerators and seed competitions exist, widespread, accessible seed funding and structured mentor networks for student ventures remain limited; the World Bank and country studies flag finance and market access as barriers to scaling youth entrepreneurship.

6. Equity and Rural Relevance: Reports recommend tailoring EE to local economies — agribusiness, eco-tourism, and crafts for rural settings — and designing gender-sensitive outreach to improve participation by women and marginalized groups.

DISCUSSIONS

The findings align closely with international EE literature: experiential, contextually grounded learning yields stronger entrepreneurial competencies; institutional supports are necessary to transform learning into viable ventures; and teacher capacity is a limiting factor. Georgia's strengths include active university incubators, growing international partnerships, and a policy environment (Unified National Strategy) that recognizes employability and innovation. However, fragmentation across pilots, uneven teacher preparation, and insufficient financing hinder systemic impact. Cultural preferences for formal employment and risk aversion among families and some educators also moderate students' willingness to pursue entrepreneurship as a career path — a dynamic documented in regional labor reports. Scaling EE in Georgia therefore requires simultaneous action on curriculum, capacity, institutional pathways (from classroom to incubator), and financing/incentives.

THEORETICAL AND PRACTICAL IMPLICATIONS

The Georgian case reinforces two theoretical propositions: (1) that constructivist/experiential models are central to entrepreneurship learning in transitional economies, and (2) that EE effectiveness depends not only on pedagogy but on system interactions (policy, finance, industry linkages). For researchers, Georgia offers a case of policy intent translating gradually into institutional innovation, with observable constraints that can refine theories on scaling EE in small economies.

Practically, the conference outcomes call for systemic reforms and sustained investments. Key implications include:

- Policy Integration: Development of a national entrepreneurship education framework to align schools, universities, and vocational training.
- Teacher Development: Institutionalized training programs, possibly through partnerships with incubators and international organizations.
- Resource Allocation: Sustainable funding for competitions, seed grants, and incubation pathways.
- Inclusive Programming: Designing initiatives that address the needs of rural communities and promote gender equity.
- Industry Linkages: Strengthening university-industry partnerships to provide internships, mentorship, and real-world projects.

CONCLUSION

Entrepreneurship education in Georgia has advanced from scattered pilots toward more institutionalized practices — university incubators, international partnerships, and policy signals in the national strategy. Yet systemic scaling requires coordinated policy action, investments in teacher capacity, sustainable financing for student ventures, and inclusive programming tailored to regional economies. Aligning experiential pedagogy with clear institutional pathways and market linkages will increase the likelihood that classroom entrepreneurship translates into sustainable ventures and improved youth employability. Continued monitoring, rigorous evaluations of pilot programs, and knowledge exchange across Georgian institutions will be essential to build an enduring EE ecosystem.

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აბსტრაქტი

მენარმეობის განათლება (MG) გახდა სტრატეგიული პრიორიტეტი საქართველოსთვის, რადგან ის ხელს უწყობს ინოვაციებს, სამუშაო ადგილების შექმნას და ეკონომიკის დივერსიფიკაციას. ნაშრომი იკვლევს მენარმეობის განათლების პრაქტიკებს საქართველოში და ეყრდნობა ეროვნული პოლიტიკის დოკუმენტებს, საერთაშორისო შეფასებებს და უახლესი კონფერენციებისა და სემინარების შედეგებს. ანალიზი წარმოაჩენს როგორც მიღწევებს, ასევე არსებულ გამოწვევებს მენარმეობის საგანმანათლებლო სისტემაში ინტეგრირების თვალსაზრისით. შედეგები მიუთითებს, რომ უნივერსიტეტები ცენტრალურ როლს ასრულებენ ინკუბატორების, სტარტაპ-კონკურსებისა და საერთაშორისო პარტნიორობების მეშვეობით, ხოლო საშუალო და პროფესიული განათლება სულ უფრო მეტად ითვისებს მენარმეობის კომპეტენციებს სასწავლო გეგმებში. გამოცდილებაზე დაფუძნებული სწავლების მიდგომები — როგორიცაა ჰაკათონები, სტაჟირებები და სტუდენტების მიერ მართული საწარმოები — ხაზგასმულია როგორც ეფექტური პრაქტიკები. თუმცა, მნიშვნელოვანი დაბრკოლებები კვლავ რჩება, მათ შორის პედაგოგთა გადამზადება, დაფინანსებაზე არასაკმარისი წვდომა და სოფლად და მარგინალიზებულ ჯგუფებში არათანაბარი მონაწილეობა. დისკუსია საქართველოს ძალისხმევას საერთაშორისო ლიტერატურის კონტექსტში განიხილავს და ხაზს უსვამს სისტემური მხარდაჭერის, ინდუსტრიასთან კავშირებისა და პოლიტიკური თანმიმდევრულობის მნიშვნელობას.

მიუხედავად იმისა, რომ საქართველო პილოტური ინიციატივებიდან ინსტიტუციონალიზებულ პრაქტიკებამდე წინ წავიდა, მასშტაბირება მოითხოვს მდგრად რეფორმებს პედაგოგთა განვითარების, ინკლუზიური პროგრამირებისა და რესურსების განაწილების სფეროებში. გარდამავალი ეკონომიკის მენარმეობის განათლებაზე დებატები და პრაქტიკულობა სთავაზობს პოლიტიკის შემქმნელებს, პედაგოგებსა და ინდუსტრიის დაინტერესებულ მხარეებს ახალ ხედვებს, რომლებიც ცდილობენ მენარმეობის განათლების განმტკიცებას მდგრადი განვითარების მამოძრავებელ ძალად.

საკვანძო სიტყვები: მენარმეობის განათლება, ინოვაცია, პროფესიული და უმაღლესი განათლება, პოლიტიკის რეფორმა.